

Mobilizing Anger in Local School Board Politics

July 1, 2026

Abstract

Race-conscious education in American public schools has become increasingly polarized. We develop a theory that exposure to information attributing racial inequality to structural causes threatens the meritocratic beliefs of privileged groups, triggering emotional reactions that shape political participation. Two original survey experiments test this theory. In the first, we rule out the possibility that emotional reactions stem from discomfort. In the second, we find that white respondents reported significantly higher anger when presented with a textbook excerpt attributing inequality to discrimination against Black people. This anger, in turn, is associated with greater intentions to attend school board meetings and with the costly behavioral choice to donate one's survey reward. These results demonstrate that anger is the dominant emotional response to educational materials that highlight racial stratification among whites. Moreover, anger can mobilize political engagement, suggesting that emotional reactions to school books are a critical mechanism linking education to politics.

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Compliance with Ethical Standards This study was deemed exempt by the institutional review board at the authors' institution on 08/28/2022, and the authors confirm that participants gave informed consent to participate and to have the results of this study published. The authors also report no conflicts of interest.

Introduction

Local school board meetings, ordinarily among the quietest venues in American politics, have in recent years become flashpoints for conflict over how race and racism are taught to children. The dominant narrative casts these battles as one more front in a familiar partisan war: Republicans mobilize against initiatives like DEI and CRT while Democrats defend those initiatives. But this framing obscures a puzzle. The emotion that animates these fights, anger, does not divide neatly along party lines. Many white Democrats, like white Republicans, bristle when told that racial discrimination, rather than individual effort, explains why whites fare better than Black Americans in the labor market. This adherence to the belief that the U.S. is a functioning meritocracy is rooted in a broader belief that America is *colorblind* — one we elaborate on later in the paper. If partisanship fully structured these reactions, we would not expect racially liberal and racially conservative whites to respond with comparable emotional intensity. Why, then, does challenging colorblindness provoke anger across the partisan divide?

This question is even more puzzling given how thoroughly the literature has tied racial attitudes to partisanship. Since at least the 1980s, scholars have found that white racial attitudes have increasingly sorted along partisan lines. The racial realignment of the two major parties triggered the partisan divides we observe today across explicitly and implicitly racialized policy domains, including affirmative action and welfare. More recently, scholars have proposed that partisanship shapes not just preferences for racial redistribution but also preferences for how racism is discussed in corporate and educational settings (Safarpour et al., 2024; Giersch, 2025). Battles over DEI and CRT have accordingly been explained as an extension of this same partisan sorting.

Yet this partisan story masks substantive variation in racial attitudes *within* parties. Colorblind racism, a racial attitude grounded in principles of racial liberalism, varies substantially among white Americans regardless of party (Bonilla-Silva, 2006; Mills, 2017). One of its core frames is meritocratic individualism: the belief that hard work, not race, deter-

mines life outcomes. In a post-Civil Rights, post-Obama America, the notion that merit matters more than race enjoys widespread support among racially liberal white Democrats. (Bonilla-Silva and Dietrich, 2011). Partisanship, in short, largely explains *whether* race matters. However, it explains far less about *how* race matters, leaving unaddressed the ideological conflict at the heart of debates over how racism and racial discrimination should be discussed in schools.

If adherence to colorblindness, rather than partisanship, is the more relevant cleavage, then the question becomes: What leads individuals to adopt or defend colorblind beliefs? Research in political psychology suggests that the answer lies, at least in part, in the emotions that racial attitudes evoke. White anger in particular has been linked to symbolic racism and ethnocentrism (Banks 2014; Banks and Valentino 2012; Banks and Bell 2013). Crucially, anger’s mobilizing effects are asymmetric not along partisan lines but along racial ones: whites, more than Black Americans or other minorities, are mobilized by anger (Phoenix, 2019), and both contemporary and historical backlash to race-conscious policies has been characterized as driven by white, not partisan, outrage (Davis and Wilson, 2021; Anderson, 2016; Hooker, 2023). What remains unexamined, however, is whether this same anger is activated when colorblindness itself is directly challenged.

We argue that whites become angry when confronted with the prospect of colorblind ideologies being challenged in public schools, and that this anger uniquely drives an influx of white participation on matters where the average citizen typically defers to the discretion of local education board members and professionals. The key cleavage, in our account, is not partisan disagreement over *whether* race matters, but divergent emotional reactions to explanations of *how* it matters. When the discussion turns from the general existence of racial inequality to identifying discrimination as the cause of whites’ elevated status and Black Americans’ lower status, structural accounts imply that white Americans benefit from racial advantages, and that implication provokes anger among some whites while leaving others unmoved. Because this anger operates through racial rather than partisan channels,

we expect it to mobilize white Democrats and white Republicans alike. We further expect the substance of that anger to differ: some white Democrats are angry that white racial advantage harms Black Americans, while others are angry precisely because the claim that race shapes outcomes threatens a colorblindness they hold dear.

We test these expectations using two original survey experiments that include open-ended measures of emotion. Respondents learn that a nearby public school textbook will teach students that discrimination causes the racial gap in unemployment, but we randomize whether the textbook frames discrimination as a product of White advantage or Black disadvantage. We then measure anger using standardized emotion measures and estimate mediation effects using the framework developed by Imai et al. (2011) and Tingley et al. (2014). We assess whether anger mediates the effect of the treatment on intentions to participate in local school board activities and to donate respondents' survey reward. Finally, we leverage respondents' open-ended responses to examine the mechanism linking the treatment to anger more directly.

We find that white people become angry when told a textbook will teach that discrimination is the cause of the unemployment gap between whites and Black Americans. This anger mediates both intent to engage with local school boards and intent to donate. The increase is symmetric across party identification: white Democrats and white Republicans both express significantly more anger when the stimulus highlights racial discrimination than when it merely describes the gap, and neither group responds with anger when no cause is named. Finally, the open-ended data reveal a substantive divide among white Democrats in the quality of their anger. Some express anger that white advantage exists and harms Black Americans, articulating a racially liberal account of the gap. Others, much like Republicans, reject any link between employment and race, invoking work ethic or other individual- or group-level factors instead. This divide confirms that white anger mobilizes across party lines, and that many Democrats, like Republicans, hold racially conservative beliefs.

This paper challenges the assumption that racial attitudes are sorted neatly by partisan-

ship. While clear divides separate white Democrats and Republicans on some racial issues, anger emerges here as a force that crosses party lines: it is challenging colorblindness, not partisan identity, that activates it. Many white Democrats, like their Republican counterparts, hold racially conservative beliefs and respond to challenges to colorblind ideology with the same emotional intensity. These findings suggest that the school board battles described at the outset are expressions of a racial, not partisan, anger that party labels obscure rather than explain. In identifying the limits of partisanship as an account of racial liberalism, the paper speaks to research on racial attitudes and partisan sorting and to a growing literature on the role of emotion in mobilizing racial politics.

Racial Attitudes Beyond Partisan Sorting

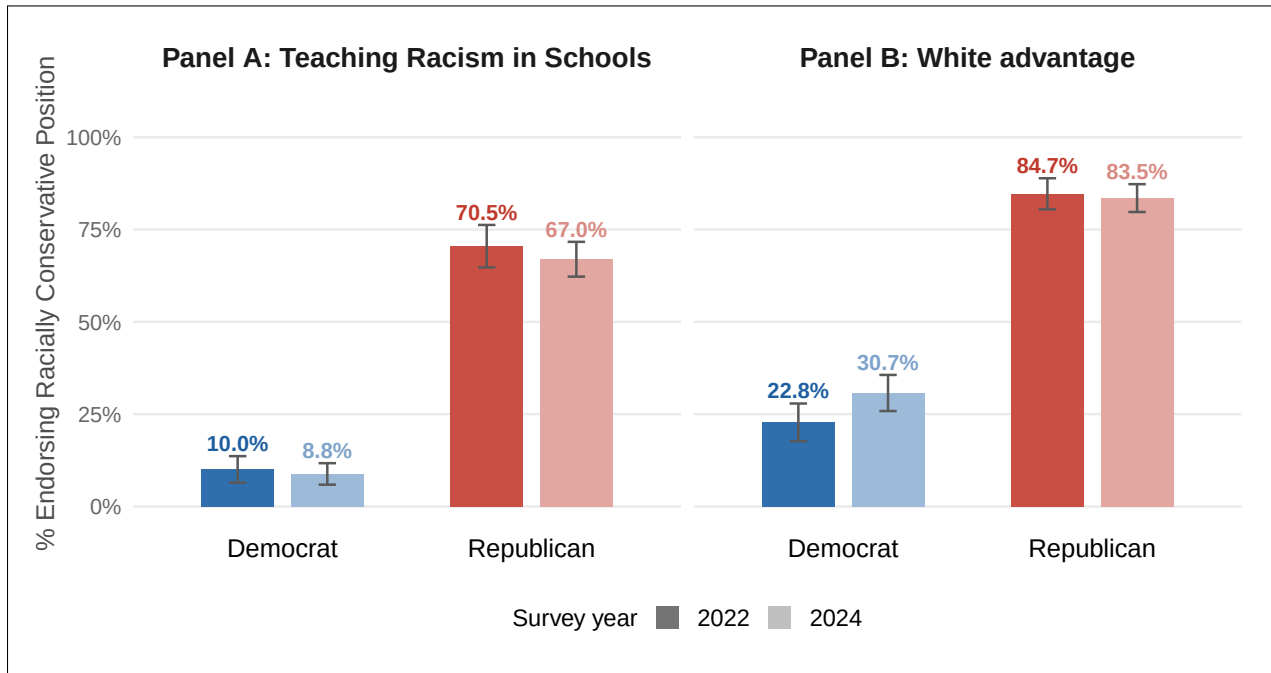
Scholars have documented a growing alignment between partisan identity and racial attitudes among white Americans. White Democrats have become increasingly supportive of race-conscious policies, while white Republicans have become increasingly opposed to them, contributing to the contemporary association between Democratic partisanship and racial liberalism and Republican partisanship and racial conservatism (Engelhardt, 2021, 2023; Mikkelsen, 2025; Jardina and Ollerenshaw, 2022). This realignment has also been used to explain contemporary conflicts surrounding diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives and Critical Race Theory (CRT), which are often interpreted as another manifestation of partisan sorting on race (Deshpande et al., 2024; Safarpour et al., 2024). Under this view, opposition to race-conscious education reflects the broader movement of Democrats into racially liberal positions and Republicans into racially conservative ones.

This account explains broad differences between Democrats and Republicans, but it leaves an important puzzle unresolved. Contemporary conflicts over race-conscious education are not simply disagreements over whether race matters politically; they are disagreements over *how* racial inequality should be understood. Should racial disparities be attributed primar-

ily to structural discrimination, or to individual effort and merit? We argue that partisan identification alone cannot fully explain these competing understandings of racial inequality and, in fact, masks important heterogeneity within the Democratic coalition.

Our theoretical framework makes three contributions. First, we demonstrate that partisan sorting obscures politically consequential heterogeneity among white Democrats. Second, we argue that the asymmetric composition of partisan coalitions, rather than sorting itself, helps explain why this heterogeneity is especially visible within the Democratic coalition. Third, we contend that colorblind ideology provides a more appropriate framework for understanding contemporary conflicts over race-conscious education because these debates center on competing explanations for racial inequality rather than simply preferences over race-conscious public policy.

Figure 1: **White Democrats are More Divided About White Advantage than Teaching Racism**



White respondents' endorsement of racially conservative positions on two ANES pilot questions. White partisan gaps in racial attitudes depend on question framing. Panel A reports the percentage of white respondents who believe schools place too much emphasis on race and racism in ANES 2022 or that schools should place little to no emphasis on racism's impact in society in ANES 2024. Panel B reports the percentage denying that being white confers structural advantages. Party identification is measured using the seven-point ANES scale, with partisan leaners grouped with their respective parties and pure independents excluded. Darker shaded bars indicate 2022 estimates and lighter shaded bars indicate 2024 estimates. Bars represent survey-weighted percentages and error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. White respondents only. *N*: 2022—Democrats = 374, Republicans = 320; 2024—Democrats = 412–416, Republicans = 501–505, depending on item nonresponse.

Figure 1 illustrates this puzzle using observational data from the 2022 and 2024 ANES Pilot Studies (American National Election Studies 2022, 2024). Panel A reproduces the familiar pattern documented throughout the literature on partisan sorting. White Republicans are substantially more likely than white Democrats to endorse minimizing discussions of race and racism in public schools. Viewed in isolation, these results suggest that racial attitudes surrounding education have become sharply polarized along partisan lines.

Panel B reveals a different pattern, however. When respondents are instead asked whether

being white confers structural advantages, endorsement of a colorblind position increases substantially among white Democrats. Although white Democrats remain less likely than Republicans to reject structural advantage, they become considerably more divided than they appeared on the school curriculum question. If partisan sorting alone explained white racial attitudes, we would expect Democratic respondents to exhibit comparable levels of agreement across both questions. Instead, substantial heterogeneity emerges once attention shifts from whether schools should discuss racism to whether racial inequality reflects structural advantage.

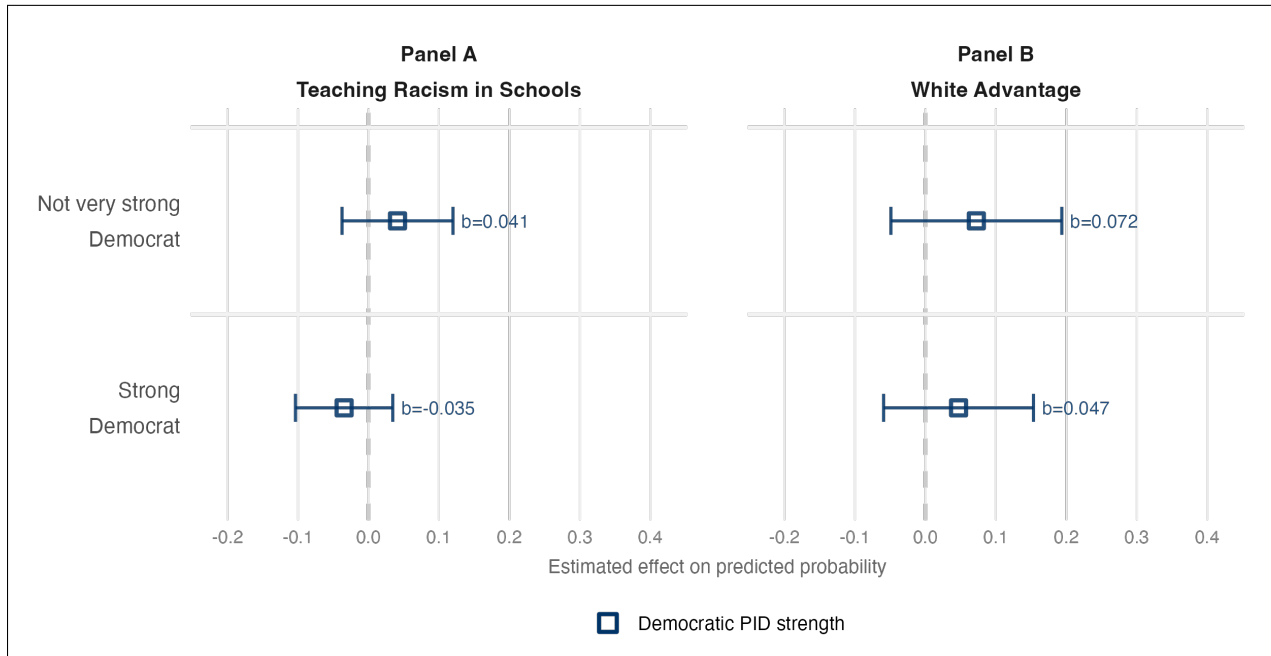
Figure 2 takes a step toward explaining this heterogeneity. Using white Democrats from the 2024 ANES Pilot Study, we estimate survey-weighted linear probability models predicting endorsement of the two colorblind attitudes shown in Figure 1. Specifically, we model support for minimizing schools' emphasis on racism and denial that whites benefit from structural advantage as functions of Democratic partisan strength. If the heterogeneity observed in Figure 1 simply reflects differences in partisan commitment, stronger Democratic identifiers should be less likely to endorse colorblind positions than Democratic leaners.

The results provide little support for this expectation. Democratic partisan strength is not significantly associated with either outcome. Strong Democrats are no less likely than Democratic leaners to reject structural accounts of racial inequality or to oppose emphasizing racism in schools. These findings suggest that the heterogeneity observed in Figure 1 is not simply a consequence of weaker Democratic identification.

Importantly, this does not imply that established measures of racial attitudes have become uninformative. These measures remain useful for identifying respondents who reject structural explanations of racial inequality. Our argument is not that prior measures have ceased to matter, but that contemporary debates over race-conscious education activate a broader ideological conflict concerning how racial inequality should be understood.

Research on the asymmetric nature of partisan coalitions further suggests why this variation is especially visible among white Democrats. Republican identity increasingly sorts onto

Figure 2: **Democratic Partisanship Strength Does Not Predict White Attitudes About Teaching Racism and White Advantage**



The likelihood of white Democrats adopting racially conservative positions on two substantive dimensions, teaching about racism in schools and white structural advantage, modeled as a function of Democratic partisan strength. Democratic partisan strength is measured using the three Democratic categories of the seven-point ANES party identification scale, with Lean Democrat serving as the baseline. Points show coefficient estimates from survey-weighted linear probability models estimated among white Democrats in the 2024 ANES Pilot. Horizontal lines represent 95% confidence intervals. Panel A models support for minimizing schools' emphasis on racism's impact in society; Panel B models denial of white structural advantage. Models include age, education, and gender as controls. Sample restricted to white Democrats, including Democratic leaners (N=412–414, depending on item nonresponse).

a relatively narrow set of social identities, whereas the Democratic coalition remains substantially more heterogeneous (Grossmann and Hopkins, 2016; Mason and Wronski, 2018). Consequently, agreement on partisan identity does not necessarily imply agreement about the causes of racial inequality. White Democrats may share preferences for Democratic candidates and many race-conscious policies while continuing to disagree about whether structural discrimination or individual effort best explains persistent racial disparities.

This broader disagreement is captured more directly by colorblind ideology than by partisanship alone. Colorblind ideology is grounded in principles of abstract liberalism, empha-

sizing individual responsibility, meritocracy, and equal treatment while minimizing the role of structural discrimination in producing racial inequality (Bonilla-Silva, 2006; Mills, 2017). Rather than denying that racial disparities exist, colorblind ideology attributes those disparities primarily to differences in effort, culture, or individual behavior. The widespread appeal of these principles allows colorblind beliefs to persist across partisan coalitions, including among many white Democrats (Bonilla-Silva and Dietrich, 2011). As a result, individuals who otherwise identify with the Democratic Party may nevertheless reject structural explanations of racial inequality when those explanations challenge deeply held meritocratic beliefs.

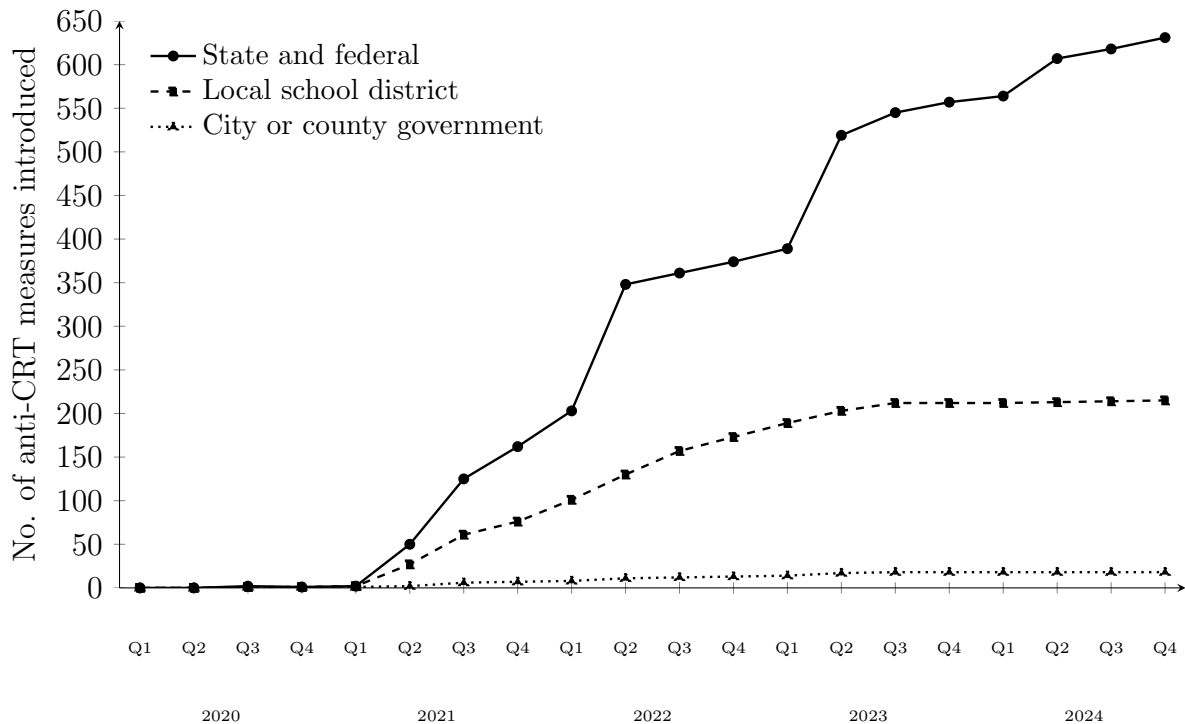
This distinction is particularly important because contemporary conflicts surrounding DEI initiatives and race-conscious education concern precisely these competing explanations of racial inequality. The central question is not whether racial inequality exists but whether schools should teach that discrimination continues to shape present-day outcomes. Put differently, these debates pit colorblind understandings of race against structural understandings of inequality.

These competing understandings are not merely abstract beliefs. They have become central to one of the defining political conflicts of the past decade. Public education has long served as a political battleground over race, from resistance to school desegregation to conflicts over busing and affirmative action. The resurgence of school board politics beginning in 2020 therefore represents less a new conflict than the latest manifestation of longstanding disputes over how Americans understand racial inequality.

This time, however, the conflict centers on *how* children are taught about racism and its continuing consequences (López and Sleeter, 2023). Figure 3 plots the number of state, federal, county, city, and local school district measures introduced between 2020 and 2024 seeking to prohibit or restrict educational materials concerning race, structural discrimination, Critical Race Theory, diversity initiatives, or claims that meritocracy itself may perpetuate racial inequality. More than 800 such measures have been introduced or enacted during this

period, illustrating that debates over how schools explain racial inequality have become a substantive arena of policymaking rather than merely symbolic culture-war politics.

Figure 3: Number of Anti-CRT Measures Introduced by Level of Government, 2020–2024



Note: Table produced from data compiled by the University of California CRT Forward Project (Alexander et al., 2023).

Colorblindness, Anger, and Political Participation

The preceding section shows that partisan sorting alone cannot explain white Americans’ reactions to contemporary conflicts over race-conscious education. Although these conflicts are often described as partisan battles over DEI or CRT, the underlying disagreement is more specific: whether racial inequality should be explained through structural discrimination or through individual effort, merit, and behavior. We argue that this distinction is central to understanding both emotional reactions and political participation. When public schools teach that racial disparities are produced by discrimination, they challenge colorblind understandings of American society. For whites who hold those understandings, such information

threatens the belief that social outcomes are earned through effort rather than shaped by racial advantage.

Public education provides an especially useful setting for testing our theory. Debates over race in schools allow us to hold the broader issue constant while varying how racial inequality is explained. Rather than relying on highly partisan labels such as CRT or DEI, our experiment contrasts two conceptually distinct frames: one stating that racial discrimination makes it harder for Black Americans to get jobs, and another stating that racial discrimination makes it easier for White Americans to get jobs. This design allows us to isolate whether challenges to colorblind ideology produce anger and whether that anger mobilizes participation across partisan lines.

With this in mind, our theoretical framework unfolds in four steps. We first explain why teaching about race in schools elicits anger, then examine the quality and underlying sources of that anger, consider its mobilizing consequences, and finally argue that partisan identification alone cannot account for the observed heterogeneity.

First, we argue that information attributing racial inequality to discrimination should activate anger among white respondents. At this stage, our theory concerns the *quantity* of anger rather than its *quality*: white respondents may become angry for different reasons, but we expect anger to increase across the board when schools are described as teaching that racial discrimination shapes socioeconomic outcomes.

This expectation also builds on work showing that white Americans' beliefs about the causes of racial inequality are closely tied to emotional reactions, especially anger (Banks and Valentino, 2012; Banks, 2014). However, our argument shifts the emphasis away from racial resentment as the primary theoretical mechanism. We do not claim that anger arises only from resentment toward Black Americans or from opposition to race-targeted benefits. Instead, we argue that anger can emerge when structural explanations of inequality challenge colorblind beliefs about merit, effort, and deserved status. In this sense, the relevant threat is not only that Black Americans are portrayed as disadvantaged, but that White Americans

are portrayed as advantaged. This leads to our first hypothesis “*Anger activation*”:

Hypothesis 1: Anger Activation *White respondents who learn that local schools may teach students that racial discrimination contributes to racial inequality will experience more anger than those who do not receive this information.*

Second, we argue that anger should be especially pronounced when the same inequality is framed in terms of white advantage rather than Black disadvantage. This is because colorblind ideology rests on the claim that race should not matter and that social outcomes largely reflect individual effort, ability, and merit (Bonilla-Silva, 2006; Mills, 2017). Information that attributes racial inequality to discrimination challenges this worldview by shifting responsibility away from individual behavior and toward social structure. In the context of public education, this challenge is especially politically charged because schools are not merely presenting information; they are authorizing a particular explanation of racial inequality for children. If respondents hold colorblind understandings of race, they should experience such curricula as threatening because the material disputes the legitimacy of meritocratic explanations for white advantage.

This logic is consistent with appraisal theories of emotion. Anger arises when individuals perceive a threat or violation, identify an external source of blame, and feel motivated to confront or control the threat (Lazarus, 1991; Smith and Ellsworth, 1985; Lerner and Keltner, 2001). When textbook material attributes racial inequality to discrimination, respondents who reject structural explanations may blame schools, educators, or political actors for promoting an account of inequality they view as illegitimate. In this context, anger is not simply a response to racial inequality itself. It is a response to the institutional endorsement of a structural explanation that challenges colorblind and meritocratic beliefs. A Black disadvantage frame emphasizes harms experienced by an outgroup, while a white advantage frame directly implicates the advantaged ingroup and challenges meritocratic self-understandings.

Thus, when racial inequality is framed as reflecting Black disadvantage rather than White advantage, we argue that white respondents will differ in the amount of anger they experience. Whereas information about Black disadvantage emphasizes the costs that discrimination imposes on Black Americans, information about white advantage highlights the benefits that discrimination confers on white Americans. We argue that the latter frame poses a more direct threat to meritocratic beliefs by implying that whites' social position may reflect unearned structural advantages rather than individual effort alone. Prior work shows that whites often respond defensively to information about white privilege by denying its relevance, emphasizing personal hardship, or distancing themselves from group advantage (Knowles et al., 2014; Phillips and Lowery, 2015). We therefore expect White advantage frames to elicit stronger anger than Black disadvantage frames. This logic motivates our second hypothesis, *"Meritocratic Threat"*:

Hypothesis 2: Meritocratic Threat *White respondents who learn that local schools may teach students that racial discrimination advantages White Americans will experience more anger than those who learn that racial discrimination disadvantages Black Americans.*

Third, we argue that anger, long understood as an approach-oriented and mobilizing emotion (Lazarus, 1991; Smith and Ellsworth, 1985; Lerner and Keltner, 2001), should increase political participation. Unlike fear, which often produces uncertainty and motivates information seeking, anger encourages individuals to confront perceived threats directly (Valentino, Gregorowicz and Groenendyk, 2009; Valentino et al., 2011; Vasilopoulos, 2018). In the context of school politics, anger should therefore increase willingness to engage with the institution perceived as responsible for promoting educational content that challenges core beliefs about individual merit and effort. Consequently, respondents who become angry in response to race-conscious curricula should be more likely to express intentions to attend school board meetings, speak during public comment, volunteer, run for school board, or

donate their survey reward. Given this, we present our third hypothesis, “*Anger Mobilization*”:

Hypothesis 3: Anger Mobilization *White respondents who experience increased anger after exposure to race-conscious education material will be more likely to express intention to participate in school board politics and to donate their survey reward.*

Finally, we argue that the effects of race-conscious curricula should not depend primarily on partisan identification. Three considerations motivate this expectation. First, although media coverage of opposition to race-conscious education has focused largely on conservatives, most school board elections are officially nonpartisan.¹ Party cues in local school board politics are therefore weak, giving respondents little reason to interpret these educational issues through a partisan lens. Second, substantial evidence suggests that white Democrats and white Republicans overlap in their beliefs about the extent to which racial inequality reflects structural versus individual causes (Feldman and Huddy, 2005). In particular, both groups endorse core elements of colorblind ideology, albeit to differing degrees (Bonilla-Silva and Dietrich, 2011; Davis and Wilson, 2021). Finally, if anger arises when individuals perceive information as threatening deeply held meritocratic beliefs, then political mobilization should depend more on adherence to those beliefs than on partisan identity itself. We therefore expect exposure to race-conscious curricula to increase anger and political engagement among white respondents across party lines. This logic motivates our final hypothesis, “*Cross-Partisan Anger Mobilization*”:

Hypothesis 4: Cross-Partisan Anger Mobilization *Anger will mediate the effect of race-conscious education material on school board participation for both white Democrats and white Republicans.*

¹According to data collected by Ballotpedia, approximately 90% of school boards across the country are elected in nonpartisan elections.

Experimental Design & Estimation Strategy

To estimate the causal effects of whites’ racial attitudes and anger on school board political participation, we designed and implemented a survey experiment ($n=2000$) fielded through a YouGov sample in the summer of 2023. 63% of our sample identified solely as non-Hispanic white, leaving us with a total of 1,300 respondents for analysis. The sample was evenly split between men and women.²

Our design represents two important innovations in studies of white racial attitudes around education policy. First, existing experimental work in this area (Safarpour et al., 2024; Deshpande et al., 2024; Collins, 2024) uses stimuli with vague references to teaching about the legacy of racism to assess white support for teaching about racism in schools. This phrasing leaves room for the possibility that whites might enthusiastically support material on historical topics like chattel slavery and Jim Crow laws, but could altogether reject educational materials that identify present-day examples of racism creating disparities between Blacks and whites. Second, our design omits any overt references to “CRT” (Critical Race Theory) or “DEI” (Diversity, Equity and Inclusion). These descriptive terms have proved to be of little use for assessing racial attitudes because they are so heavily partisan-coded. When someone says the oppose (favor) CRT, we learn very little about them beyond their partisan affiliation (Deshpande et al., 2024). Our design thus presents a novel test of how language about race that is not partisan-coded elicits emotional responses from white Americans.

For our experimental intervention, we informed respondents that a textbook company is considering changing one of its textbooks and is soliciting opinions on those changes. Respondents viewed one of three randomly assigned excerpts from a hypothetical middle school social studies textbook.³ Each excerpt includes the same bar chart depicting the gap in unemployment rates for White and Black Americans in 2020, reported by the U.S.

²Appendix B summarizes the demographics of our white sample.

³See the Appendix B for sampling procedures and consent procedures.

Bureau of Labor Statistics. In all three conditions, we kept the length of the excerpt roughly similar. Table 1 summarizes the manipulations in each condition which center on the title of the module and the framing of the bar chart. First, our control condition treats attribution for the racial gap in unemployment as an open question, framing the cause as a debate among economists. This condition allowed us to prime race without attributing the unemployment gap to racial discrimination.

Next, our two treatment conditions include the same title for the bar chart, “Figure 5.6: Does racial discrimination cause differences in unemployment by race?” In the “Easier for whites” condition, we add an explanation about the unemployment gap by stating in bold font: “Economists find that racial discrimination makes it easier for White Americans to get jobs.” This graphic includes a “key term” learning tool defining “racial discrimination” as “when one group gets *better* opportunities than another group because of the color of their skin”. In the “Harder for Blacks” condition, the explanation about the unemployment gap reads: “Economists find that racial discrimination makes it harder for Black Americans to get jobs.” Here, the key term defines racial discrimination as “when one group gets *worse* opportunities because of the color of their skin.” Table 1 summarizes our experimental conditions. The Appendix (C.1) includes the full wording and an image of how the textbook intervention appeared to respondents for each condition.

Our treatment conditions explain the disparities in unemployment rates by directly mentioning discrimination. Given our theory, we expect that pointing to white advantage as the cause for the difference in unemployment will result in white respondents getting angry because this condition challenges colorblind explanations for racial disparities that are common among whites (Bonilla-Silva, 2006). A subtle yet significant difference we anticipate is that cuing white advantage brings to the forefront the idea that fixing inequality necessitates whites giving up resources, which should induce more anger compared to cuing Black disadvantage, which does not implicate whites losing their advantage (Lowery et al., 2006).⁴

⁴The full text and illustration for each condition can be found in Appendix C.1.

Table 1: Summary of Experimental Stimuli (Social Studies Textbook Module)

Condition	Module Title	Framing
Control	What causes differences in unemployment by race?	No mention of racial discrimination
Easier for Whites	Does racial discrimination cause differences in unemployment by race?	Discrimination makes it easier for White Americans to get jobs
Harder for Blacks	Does racial discrimination cause differences in unemployment by race?	Discrimination makes it harder for Black Americans to get jobs

Note: All conditions included an identical image depicting the unemployment gap between Black and white Americans. Conditions vary *only* in whether and how the racial employment gap is attributed to *racial discrimination*. See SI C.1 for full treatment modules.

Following the excerpt, respondents are asked to report how it made them feel. They reported their intensity of emotion (from *not at all* to *extremely*) across eight emotions.⁵ Standard measures of emotions have exhibited that it is good practice to have two indicators on each emotional dimension (Valentino and Neuner, 2017; Mintz, Valentino and Wayne, 2021). As such, we operationalize anger by averaging how “angry” and “outraged” a respondent was.⁶ Likewise, we measure eight discrete emotions spanning both positive and negative valences, a common approach in political psychology that allows respondents to differentiate among related emotional reactions (e.g., anger versus fear) rather than simply reporting overall positive or negative affect (Marcus, Neuman and MacKuen 2000).

Next, we asked participants to write about how the excerpt made them feel. We asked this in an open-ended format to allow for clarity on *why* the emotions arose. For instance, while white Democrats express more support for racially redistributive policies and racial minority candidates than white Republicans, attitudes about race (especially about the causes of racial

⁵Those eight emotions map onto 4 distinct ones, including happiness, shame, fear, and anger. The current paper centers on anger, thus the remaining emotions are beyond its scope. However, we report coefficients for this emotions in the Appendix. An example of how the emotions slider question appears is included in Appendix C.2.

⁶We create an emotional index scale where 0 is a required click to distinguish between no emotion present and a non-response, 1-3 is “a little”, 4-5 “moderate”, and 6-7 “extreme”.

inequality) vary substantially among white Democrats (Feldman and Huddy, 2005). That is, liberalism on non-racial issues is not a proxy for racial liberalism, even among Whites who align themselves with the Democratic party. On the other hand, Banks suggests that white Democrats and white Republicans express anger about race for different reasons: white Republicans become angry about the idea that racism contributes to racial inequality and white Democrats experience anger about the injustice of racial inequality (Banks, 2014). The open-ended format of our questions allows us to explore differences that may exist across partisans.

Before random assignment to one of our three experimental conditions, we obtained consent from each respondent, asked basic demographic questions, and probed for partisanship with the ANES measure that includes partisan strength and the typical “leaner” questions.

Although some scholars caution against experimental designs that aim to identify mediators (Gerber and Green 2012), directly randomizing an emotion like anger runs the risk of altering the treatment itself. Following a well-established work on the mediating role of emotions (Valentino and Neuner 2017; Brader, Valentino and Suhay 2008, 2023; Valentino et al. 2008; Valentino, Gregorowicz and Groenendyk 2009; Izatt 2025), we incorporated design features that should help with reducing bias and strengthening causal inference. First, we randomized the order in which the eight emotion items appeared in the survey. While not equivalent to randomizing the mediator, this step helps minimize order effects, priming, or demand characteristics that could contaminate measurement. Second, immediately after the emotion battery, we asked respondents in an open-ended item to describe how the textbook made them feel. Following Pirlott and MacKinnon (2016)’s recommendations, this manipulation should enable us to gauge if the treatment increased negative affect in the theorized direction and provide evidence of the construct validity of our mediator.

After testing for an emotional reaction, we measure our primary outcome variable, political engagement, with a battery of 6 questions. We ask how likely a participant is to attend a hypothetical school board meeting, make a comment in the next school board meeting,

donate to the school board, run for the school board, and volunteer for the school board. We also asked respondents whether they would like to donate their YouGov reward to one of two fictitious organizations aimed at changing school curricula content.⁷

We also measure, as a potential outcome variable for future inquiry, the degree to which respondents feel that white Americans are losing influence because of racial minorities. Finally, we include a question gauging opinions about the content of curricula in public school education. Both batteries were adopted from the ANES 2022 Pilot Study.⁸

Results

Increased Anger in Response to Racial Discrimination Treatments

We first test the claim that white respondents feel increased anger when learning that a textbook module will discuss how racial discrimination advantages whites. In Figure 4, we report the main treatment effects on four emotions among white respondents. The whiskers extending from the shape correspond to a 95% confidence interval; meaning we can be reasonably confident that respondents' emotional reactions were the product of which treatment condition they were exposed to as long as the whiskers do not cross the 0.0 threshold.

Our results show that anger is the dominant emotional response to the racial discrimination treatments. Both of the treatment conditions increase anger by about 15 percentage points relative to the control. The treatments also significantly increased fear, but the increase in fear are much smaller in magnitude (around 5 percentage points) than the increases in anger. In other words, the racial discrimination treatments make respondents a little more afraid and much more angry, consistent with the theory that the racial discrimination treat-

⁷Note that we asked if participants would donate their YouGov rewards. Those who agreed were directed to a screen explaining that they could keep their reward. The question gauges a more realistic probability of a respondent's willingness to donate.

⁸A depiction of how our survey unfolds and a breakdown of the sample size in each of our experimental conditions can be found in Appendix 4.

ments threaten white’s group position. Because anger is significantly higher (p-value < .001), we can confirm our first Hypothesis 1 that white people will experience more anger than other emotions when they learn that local elementary schools are teaching about racial discrimination. Surprisingly, we find that the white advantage and Black disadvantage conditions increase anger at the same rate. We initially expected social desirability to attenuate the effects of the Black disadvantage framing, but the results indicate that simply mentioning racial discrimination in school spurs significant angry reactions among whites.

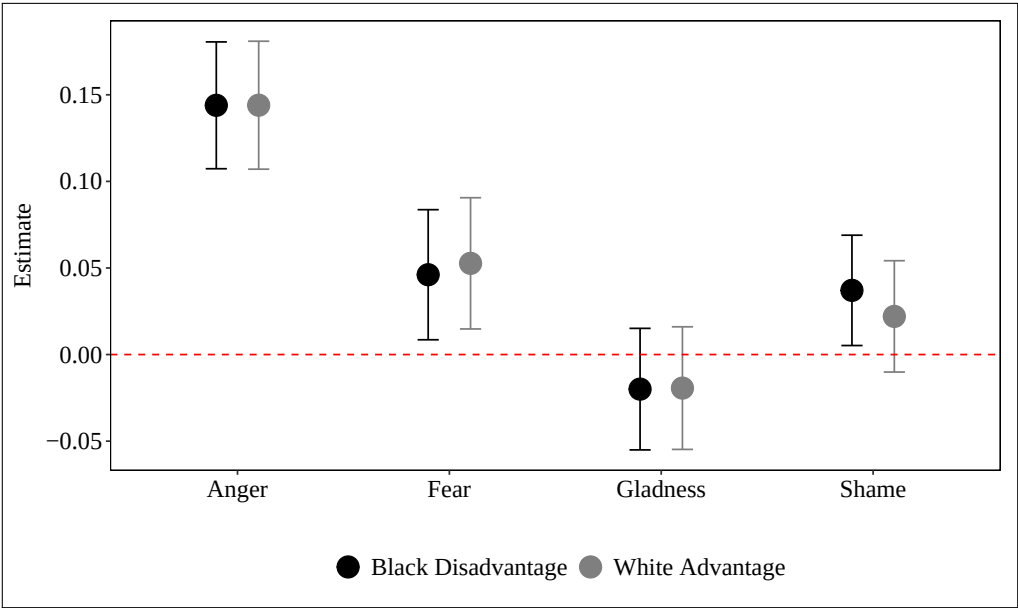
Moreover, we find no significant difference between treatment conditions when considering gladness and inconsistent effects for shame. The Black Disadvantage condition had only a small ($\beta < .05$) positive effect on shame and the White Advantage condition had no significant effect at all. The null or minimal effects for shame further indicate that the respondents feel threatened by the treatments. If anger and shame were both increased in the treatment conditions, this would suggest that whites are angry about racial injustice and ashamed that their group benefits from racial discrimination (Chudy, Piston and Shipper, 2019). However, anger without shame or guilt is less likely an emotional response to racial injustice and more likely a response to a perceived threat.

Assessing the Quality of Anger and the Role of Partisanship

To establish that these voices are representative rather than cherry-picked, we turn to *exemplary responses*, which are the responses most characteristic of each condition, obtained through Structural Topic Modeling (STM).⁹ Formally, exemplary responses are the responses that maximize estimated topic prevalence for the dominant STM topic within each condition. Let θ_{ik} denote the estimated prevalence of topic k in response i . For each condition c , we identify the dominant topic as $k_c^* = \arg \max_k \bar{\theta}_{ck}$. We then rank responses within condition c by $\theta_{ik_c^*}$ and present the three top-ranked cases as exemplary responses. In this way, the excerpts shown are those most strongly representative of the dominant discourse in each

⁹See Roberts, Stewart and Tingley (N.d.) for details on this methodology

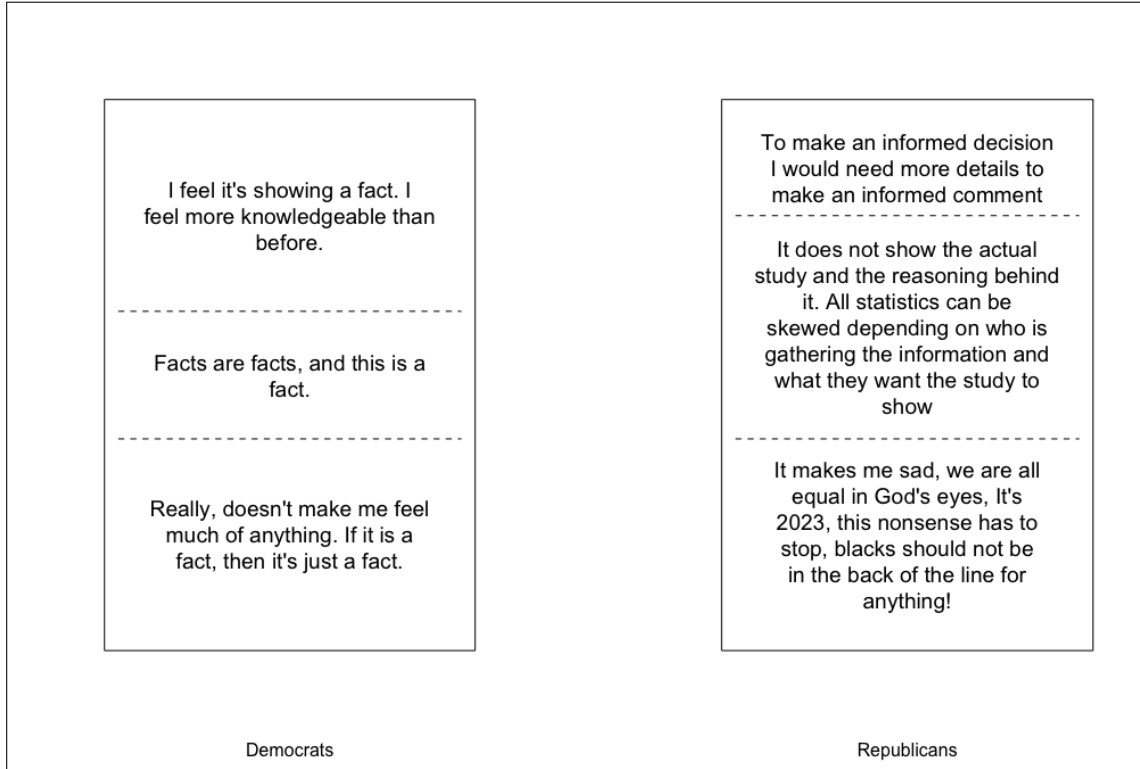
Figure 4: Effects of Attributing Unemployment Gap to White Advantage and Black Disadvantage on All Emotions



Note: Control (reference) condition for all models was bar chart of Black-white unemployment gap with no attributions to discrimination. Points are point estimates (OLS), bars are 95% confidence intervals. Red line indicates threshold for statistical significance at $p < .05$. Complete results in Appendix C.6

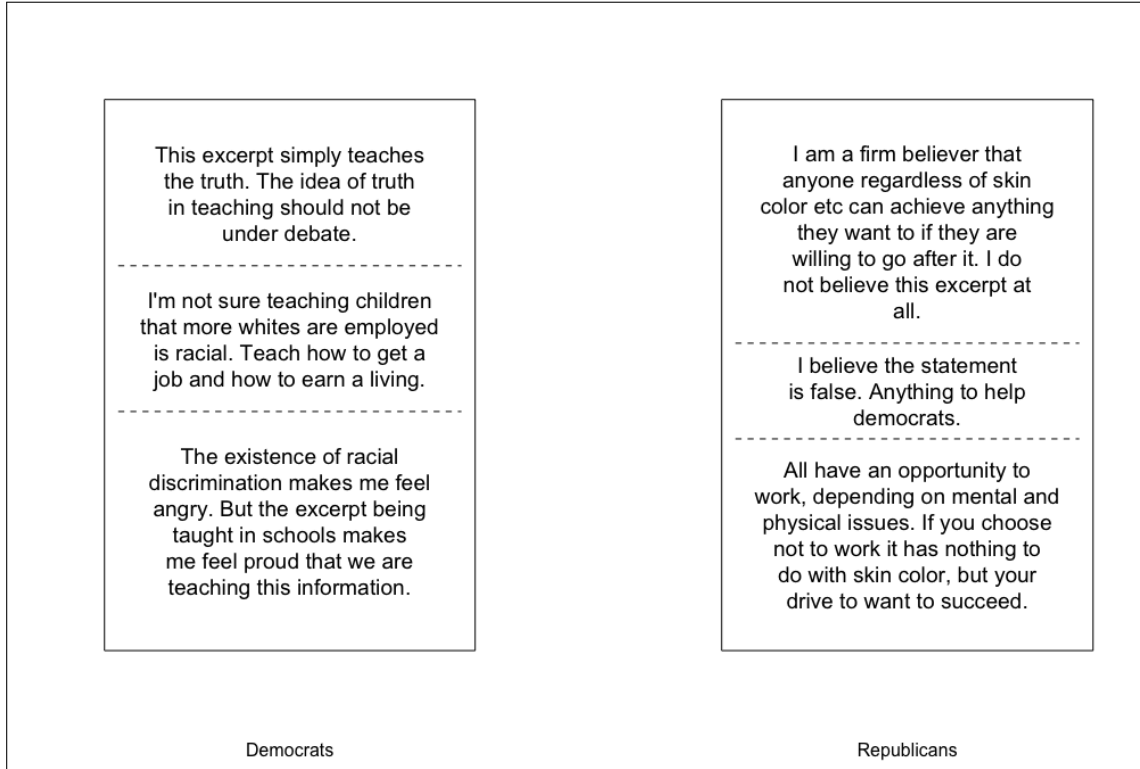
experimental condition.

Figure 5: Exemplary Responses by White Respondents in the Control Condition



We present those exemplary responses by partisanship in Figures 5, 6, and 7. In the *control* condition (Fig 5), exemplary responses from both parties simply register the information as factual: a white Democrat notes that ‘*Facts are facts and this is a fact,*’ while a white Republican explains that to make an informed decision ‘*I would need more details to make an informed comment.*’ Neither expresses threat, confirming that unqualified information about the unemployment gap does not, on its own, activate a defensive reaction.

Figure 6: Exemplary Responses by White Respondents in the “Easier for Whites” condition

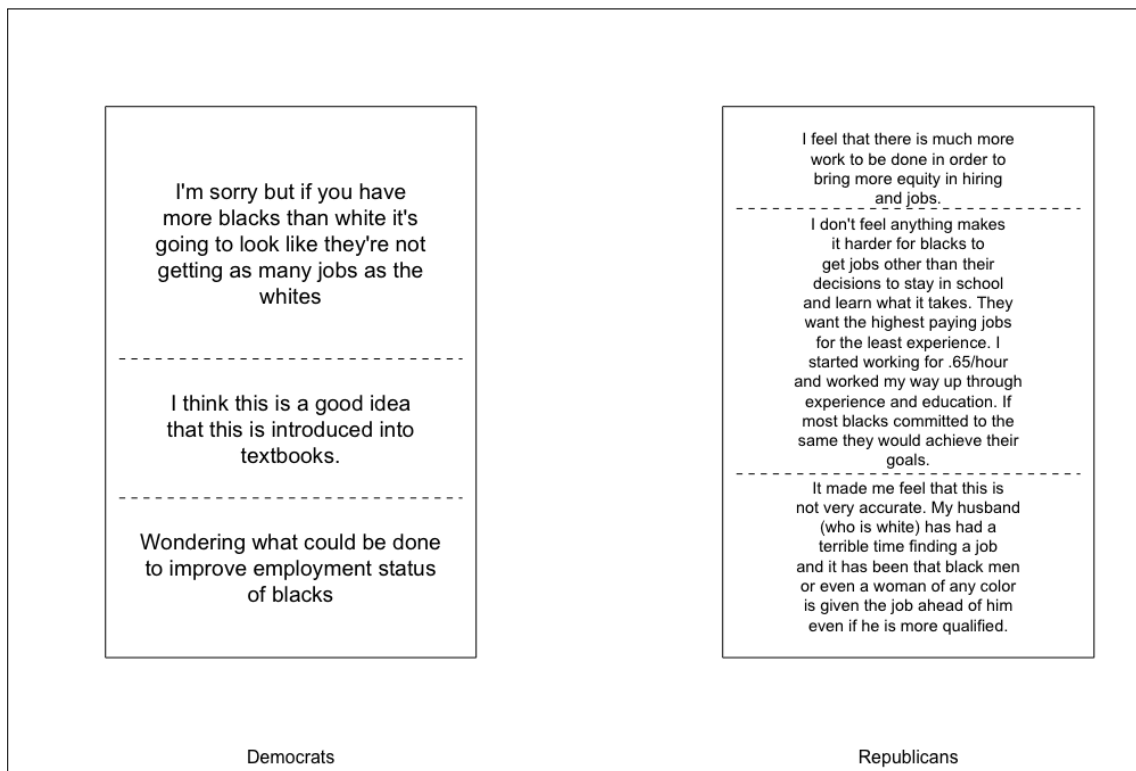


The treatment conditions, and especially the *Easier for Whites* condition (Fig 6), tell a different story. White Republicans in that condition contest the premise outright, insisting race is irrelevant to outcomes: one is a firm believer that ‘*anyone regardless of skin color etc can achieve anything they want to if they are willing to go after it*’, and another that ‘*...if you choose not to work it has nothing to do with skin color, but your drive to want to succeed*’. These responses are further evidence of backlash in response to any information that challenges the colorblind belief that America rewards effort regardless of race (Mills, 2017).

Compelling evidence for our argument of white Democrat heterogeneity is that some white Democrats in the survey sound *very* similar to Republicans in the sample. The white Democrat quoted above (Fig 6) saying ‘*Teach how to get a job and how to earn a living*’ mirrors the Republican appeal to individual effort almost verbatim, deploying a colorblind individual-blame frame and denying the role of race in structuring labor market outcomes

(Kinder and Sanders, 1996; Feldman and Huddy, 2005), and showing blindness to the role of race in disparities.

Figure 7: Exemplary Responses by White Respondents in the “Harder for Blacks” Condition

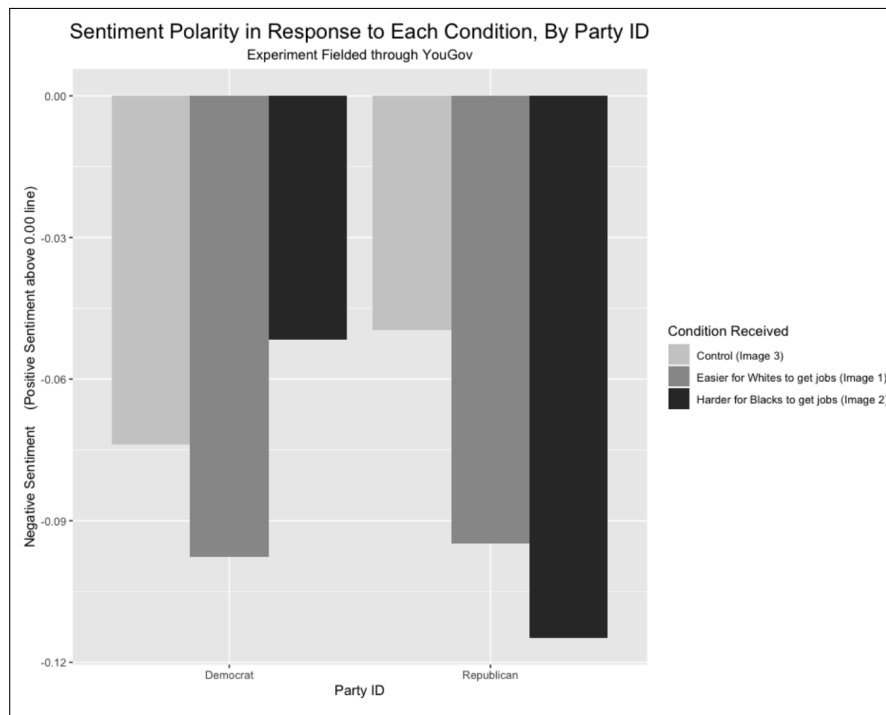


In the *Harder for Blacks* condition (Fig 7), another white Democrat questions the data itself, reasoning that *‘if you have more blacks than white, it’s going to look like they’re not getting as many jobs as the whites.’* Set against the racially liberal Democrat who is *‘proud that we are teaching this information’*, these responses make the heterogeneity unmistakable: white Democrats do not share a single emotional response to challenges to colorblindness and individual blame. Some are angry that white advantage harms Black Americans; others are angry, like Republicans, that the challenge to meritocracy is being made at all. These results are congruent with ongoing work by Hutchings et. al that shows this heterogeneity for white Democrats in the U.S.

Sentiment analysis corroborates this pattern at scale. Figure 8 reports sentiment polarity for the open-ended responses using the Harvard-IV dictionary in a lexicon-based sentiment

analysis approach. Each response is assigned a polarity score based on the relative frequency of words coded as positive and negative in the dictionary.¹⁰ Both partisan groups skew negative across all the treatment conditions, and, consistent with the partisan story, white Republicans are more negative overall, peaking in the *‘Harder for Blacks’* condition.

Figure 8: Negative Sentiment Polarity of Open-Ended Responses by Party



Note: Sentiments are classified using the Harvard-IV dictionary. See Appendix E for details and output.

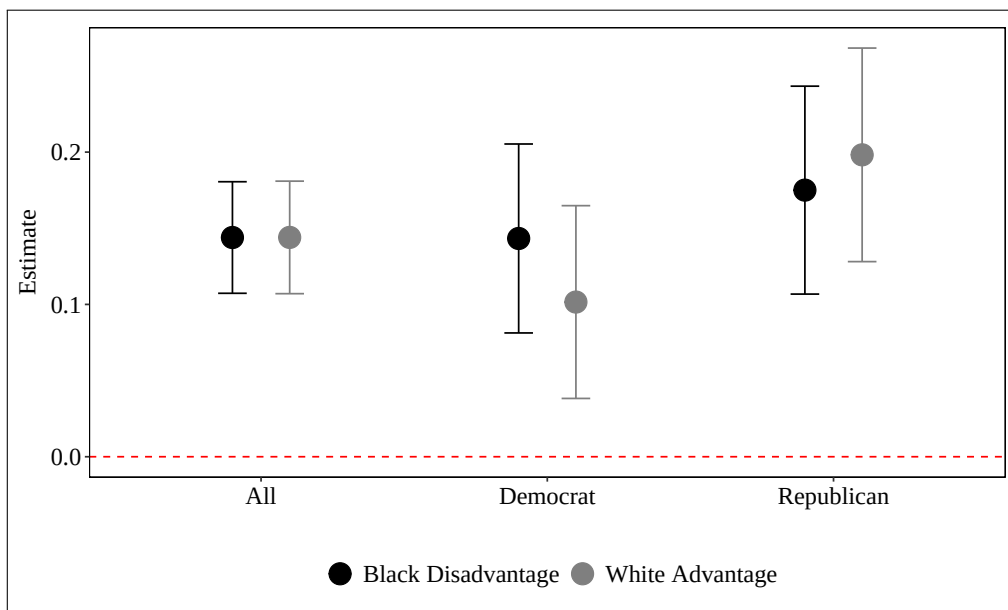
But the result that matters for our argument concerns white Democrats: although they are less negative on average, they are **more** negative in the *‘Easier for Whites’* condition than in the control, even as they are less negative in the *‘Harder for Blacks’* condition. In other words, the prompt that most directly contradicts the meritocratic claim that *“whites have more because they worked harder”* is precisely the one that pushes white Democrats

¹⁰The Harvard-IV dictionary is a lexicon-based sentiment tool that assigns words to predefined categories, including positive and negative valence. We score each response by tokenizing the text, matching words to the dictionary, and aggregating the number of positive and negative matches into a single polarity measure. This score reflects the relative frequency of positive versus negative language in the response: higher values indicate more positive sentiment, lower values indicate more negative sentiment, and values near zero indicate a more neutral balance.

toward negativity. This asymmetry is hard to reconcile with a purely partisan account and squarely supports the group-position model: it is the challenge to earned advantage, not the mention of race as such, that provokes the defensive reaction.

Finally, the closed-ended anger effects confirm that the reaction to the conditions registers as anger specifically, and across party lines. Figure 9 plots the average treatment effect on anger for all white respondents, white Democrats, and white Republicans. The treatments significantly raise anger for both groups; Republicans are somewhat angrier, but the effect is unmistakable for Democrats as well. Quantity of anger, then, is bipartisan, while its quality, as the open-ended evidence shows, divides white Democrats internally.

Figure 9: Effects of Attributing Unemployment Gap to Discrimination on Anger by Partisanship



Note: Treatment stimuli were textbooks describing discrimination *against* Black Americans (dark) and discrimination *in favor of* white Americans (gray) as the cause of the Black-white unemployment gap. Points are point estimates (OLS), bars are 95% confidence intervals. Red line indicates threshold for statistical significance at $p < .05$. Complete results in Appendix C.6 Points are point estimates (OLS). Bars are 95% Confidence Intervals. White respondents only.

Overall, we find multi-method evidence for Hypotheses 1a and 1b: the sentiment results corroborate the closed-ended finding that whites react more negatively to the treatments than the control, and the exemplary responses show this anger is driven by threats to colorblind

and meritocratic ideology among both white Democrats and white Republicans. We also find support for Hypothesis 3, which proposed that partisanship alone does not account for the quality of white anger. For both parties the treatments elicit significantly more anger and negativity than the control, yet some white Democrats describe that anger as a response to threat rather than to injustice. These findings provide strong evidence of heterogeneity among white Democrats, though our ability to characterize the quality of anger is bounded by the depth of the open-ended responses. Future work should further probe how whites respond emotionally to information that unsettles colorblind ideologies.

The Mediating Role of Emotions on Participation

Having established through two experiments that our discrimination treatments significantly increase anger among white respondents, we now turn to the mediating role of anger in shaping participation. Our theory concerns the indirect pathway, or the Average Causal Mediation Effect (ACME), rather than the direct effect (ADE) or total effect (TE), which we still report for transparency.

Thus, to evaluate whether anger mediates the effect of discrimination frames on political engagement, we employ causal mediation analysis. Following Imai, Tingley, and Yamamoto (2013), we define the ACME within the potential outcomes framework (Rubin 1974). This approach improves on traditional regression methods by formalizing the assumptions necessary for identification, providing nonparametric estimation, and offering sensitivity analyses to assess robustness. We estimate separate models for the mediator and the outcomes and recover the ACME, ADE, and TE using 10,000 nonparametric bootstrap simulations. Results are presented for both low- and high-cost forms of participation, with the prescribed sensitivity analyses included in Appendix D (Imai, Tingley and Yamamoto 2013).

In adopting this approach, our goal is to isolate the mechanism that links our experimental manipulation to our outcome variables (Druckman 2022, 2022, p. 45). Our design explicitly follows the guidance of scholars who argue that mediation can be credibly iden-

tified when design choices are aligned with theory. Consistent with this idea, we treat our experimental manipulations as what Pirlott and MacKinnon (2016) call an “encouragement design”: the race-based excerpts are expected to elevate anger relative to the control, thereby providing leverage to assess whether anger mediates the treatment effect. Likewise, Glynn (2021) emphasizes that mediation analysis is *most* useful when theory posits unobserved psychological processes and when direct effects may be weak or absent (267). Appendix C.5 shows that our treatments do not produce strong direct effects on participation, making it especially plausible (or at least worth testing) that anger is doing the implicit work of linking treatment to behavior.

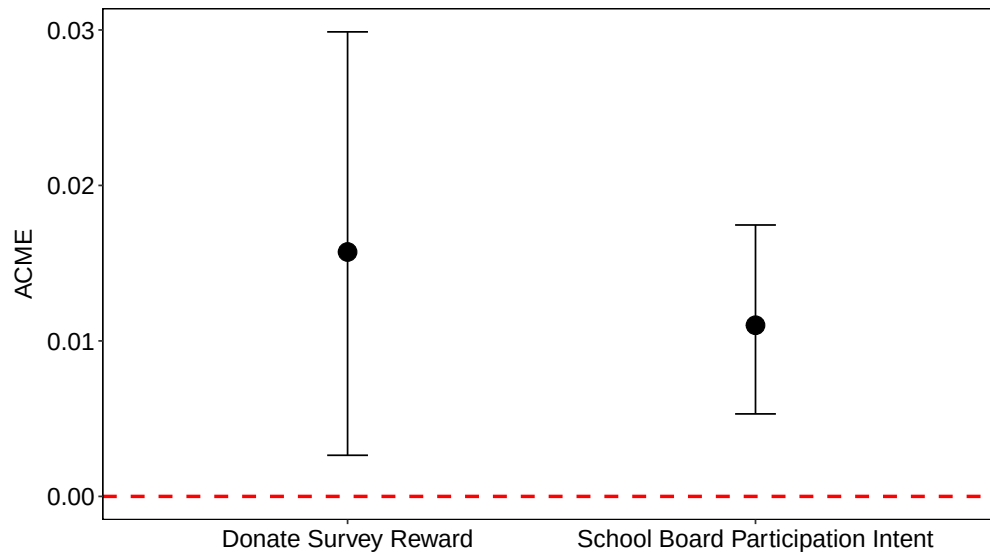
Mediation Effects of Anger

We first consider the mediating effects of anger on our participation outcomes across the full sample of white respondents. Figure 10 summarizes the mediation ¹¹ effects of anger, the direct effect of our treatment, and the total effect of both anger and the treatment on white respondents’ likelihood to engage in school board politics. These findings show that white respondents were significantly more likely to participate because they experienced anger when exposed to the treatment conditions than white respondents who were exposed to the control condition. This confirms Hypothesis 3: anger drives indirectly increased participation among white people.

Finally, we consider the heterogeneous effects of partisanship. Recall that we theorize partisanship will have no effect on how much anger perpetuates political participation when racial discrimination is cued. Figure 11 summarizes the mediating effects of anger on participation, conditioned by partisanship. When it comes to our participation index, we find anger mediates participation, regardless of partisanship. Thus, we can confirm Hypothesis 3. Respondents were more willing to participate in school board politics irrespective of partisanship. While the effects on donating their survey reward, are not significant, the direction

¹¹Tables summarizing the average direct effect and total effect for each model are available in SI C.7.

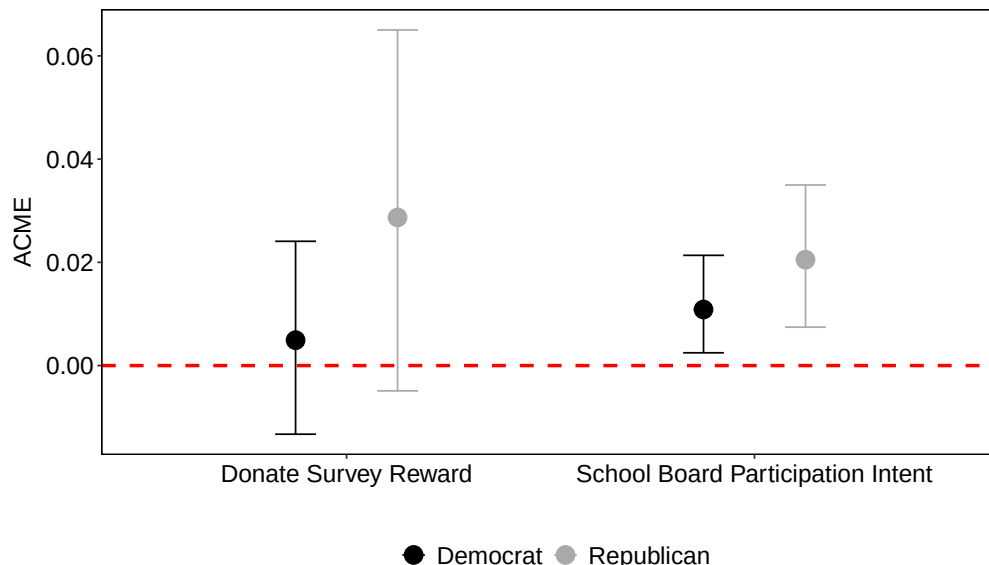
Figure 10: Anger Mediates Effect of Treatment on Intent to Participate and Donate Survey Reward



Note: Points are average causal mediation effect (ACME) of anger on participation. Bars are bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals based on $N = 10,000$ Monte Carlo Simulations. See Appendix C.7 for full mediation output

is still positive and consistent with our theoretical expectations. This implies that anger motivates intent to participate in school board politics but may not motivate respondents to donate their survey reward in real-time. Robustness checks confirm that our results after accounting for sensitivity with regard to the error term (see Appendix D).

Figure 11: Anger Mediates Effect of Treatment on Intent to Participate for White Democrats and Republicans



Note: Points are average causal mediation effect (ACME) of anger among white Democrats (light gray) and white Republicans (dark gray) on participation outcomes. Bars are bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals based on $N = 10,000$ Monte Carlo Simulations. See Appendix C.7 for full mediation output.

1 Testing an Alternative Explanation

One common alternative explanation regarding collective backlash about race-related school curricula is that parents and administrators are concerned about presenting materials to children that might make them feel uncomfortable or guilty about being white (Baldwin Clark 2023). If correct, this account would assume that anger should arise whenever school curricula attribute disadvantage to discrimination in ways that implicate students' identities, regardless of whether those identities are racial.

We test this explanation directly in a companion experiment fielded on CloudResearch ($N = 500$) in 2023. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of three conditions: a control condition, a racial discrimination condition, or a national-origin discrimination condition. The national-origin condition preserved the structure of the racial discrimination treatment but replaced Black Americans with immigrants from Canada, a group toward

which white Americans report comparatively warm attitudes (Center, 2016).¹² This design allows us to distinguish opposition to race-conscious explanations of inequality from a more general discomfort with educational materials that attribute disparities to discrimination.

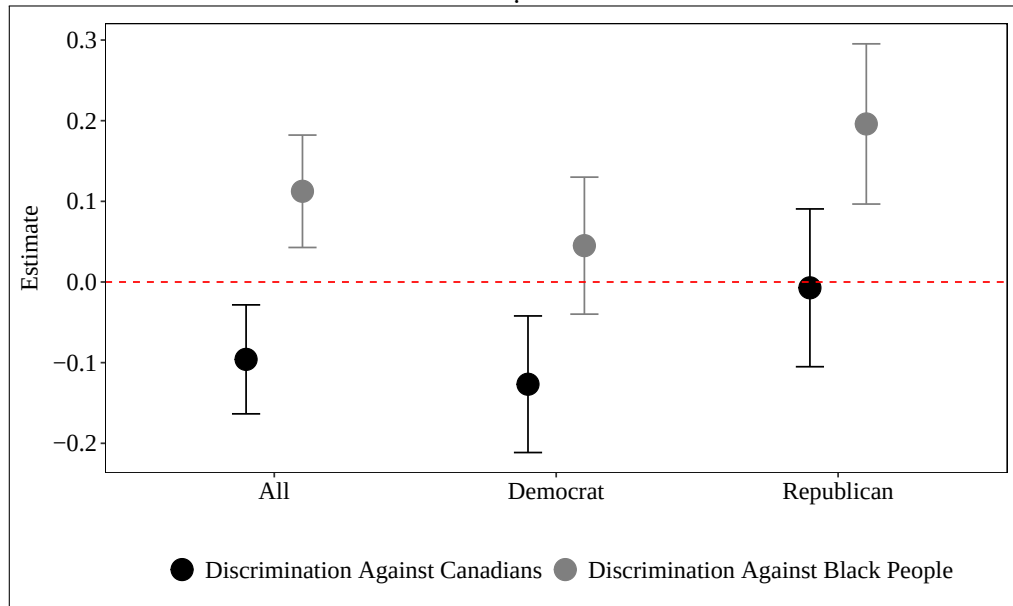
Following random assignment, the survey mirrored the design of our primary YouGov experiment. We estimate average treatment effects on reported anger using OLS regression. Figure 12 presents the results.

We find that anger levels were significantly higher among pre-test respondents randomly assigned to the racial discrimination treatment. As shown in Figure 12, white respondents expressed substantially more anger in the racial discrimination condition compared to the control, which made no mention of discrimination. By contrast, there was no statistically significant difference in anger between whites in the national origin discrimination condition and the control. In fact, the coefficient for the national origin condition is negative, suggesting that whites, if anything, felt slightly less anger when told about Canadians facing labor market discrimination. Looking by partisanship, white Republicans reported significantly more anger in the racial discrimination condition relative to the control, while no difference emerged between control and national origin conditions. Among white Democrats, anger decreased in the national origin condition compared to control.

Overall, white people exposed to information about discrimination against Canadians experienced very little anger relative to those in the racial discrimination condition. This additonal test supports our theoretical claim that race, specifically, triggers anger in these debates. It also challenges the narrative that white parents are motivated only by a desire to shield children from feeling bad about their identity. If that were the case, we would expect respondents to react similarly when children’s identities as Americans were implicated. These results suggest otherwise.

¹²The full text and images used for the “National Origin Discrimination” treatment can be found in Appendix C.1.

Figure 12: Differential Effects of Racial and National Origin Discrimination Attributions on Anger



Note: Treatment stimuli were textbooks describing discrimination against Black Americans (dark) and Discrimination against Canadian-Born Americans (gray) as the cause of higher rates of unemployment relative to white Americans. Points are OLS regressions. Bars are 95% confidence intervals. Complete results in Appendix C.4

Conclusion

Since 2020, the partisan divide in white racial attitudes has spilled over into the local politics of education and public school curricula. This study demonstrates that the political activism emerging from these debates is partly driven by emotions that transcend the partisan divide. Across two survey experiments, we show that educational materials that attribute racial inequality to systemic racism (especially framings of racism as system that advantages whites and disadvantages Black Americans) cause white people to experience anger more than any other emotion. We further demonstrate that mere description of racial inequality is not enough; it is the attribution of that inequality to white Americans' structural advantage that increases anger among both white Democrats and white Republicans. We show that this anger mobilizes white people to engage in costly political behavior, including donating their survey reward. Crucially, anger does not just mobilize across across party lines. We also find evidence that the quality of anger among white Democrats responds not just to racial

injustice, but to also to threats to meritocratic beliefs. An examination of nearly 1,000 open-ended responses from white Democrats and Republicans reveals substantial heterogeneity among white Democrats in their reasoning, with some even invoking behavioral explanations for racial inequality that mirror those of white Republicans. These findings illuminate how race, emotion, and education intersect to shape political behavior.

We extend research on the relationship between racial attitudes, emotions, and participation in several ways. First, our experimental results show that informational stimuli about racial discrimination trigger white anger and, to a much lesser extent, fear. The fact that textbook content cuing white advantage and Black disadvantage increases anger but has little to no effect on shame suggests that this emotional reaction is a response to meritocratic threat rather than to racial injustice, even among Democrats. Our analyses of open-ended data further support this interpretation. Cuing attributions to structural advantages for whites increased the proportion of negatively valenced emotions among white respondents. Moreover, the exemplary responses drawn from this data reveal that white respondents across party lines were angered by any suggestion that structural racism, rather than work ethic or individual effort, could explain the Black-white unemployment gap.

Second, these results add nuance to partisan polarization models of mobilization around race in school curricula. Our findings highlight the need to further investigate ideological heterogeneity among white Democrats when it comes to racial attitudes. Third, our findings contribute to a growing body of literature showing that anger mediates political participation. Specifically, our causal mediation results underscore the importance of measuring variables like emotion. While emotions are more difficult to detect, they have significant effects on participation, especially when racial issues are at hand.

More broadly, our results contribute to scholarship on the politicization of public schools. Education has long been recognized as a mechanism for transmitting civic values and shaping political identity, but the present findings underscore that schools are equally sites of contestation where group status, privilege, and legitimacy are negotiated. These battles are

neither new nor novel; they have played out in schools throughout American history. We argue that anger has been central to these debates. When schools adopt materials that foreground structural racism, they do more than educate: they provoke emotional reactions that reverberate through local and national politics.

The current study focuses on white Americans, but limitations remain for understanding non-white minority groups. The test of our theory is therefore incomplete, as we cannot rule out the possibility that Black and other non-white Americans also experience heightened anger when they learn that schools are teaching about the existence of racial disparities. Future work should oversample non-white respondents to explore the relationship between racial attitudes, emotions, and participation for these groups.

Overall, our studies show that anger, more than any other emotion, mediates the relationship between white Americans learning about school curricula about racial discrimination, and participation in school board politics. Our findings explain the political potency of debates about diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts in public education that continue to dominate public discourse. Instead of becoming angry about the mere discussion of racial differences, white Americans across party lines appear to be angry about the suggestion that racial differences are not driven by innate ability, motivation, or hard work. Simply put, white respondents are angry at the thought of children learning in schools that America is not colorblind. Any book, school material, or curriculum that declares racial disparities stem from discrimination and racial biases woven into American institutions is likely to draw significant anger from whites and, thereby, lead them to participate more in political actions. Although this study centers on school board politics, anger likely mediates the link between white racial attitudes and participation in broader domains, including presidential elections and support for race-targeted policies. Future research should test these possibilities.

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Supplementary Appendix

Contents

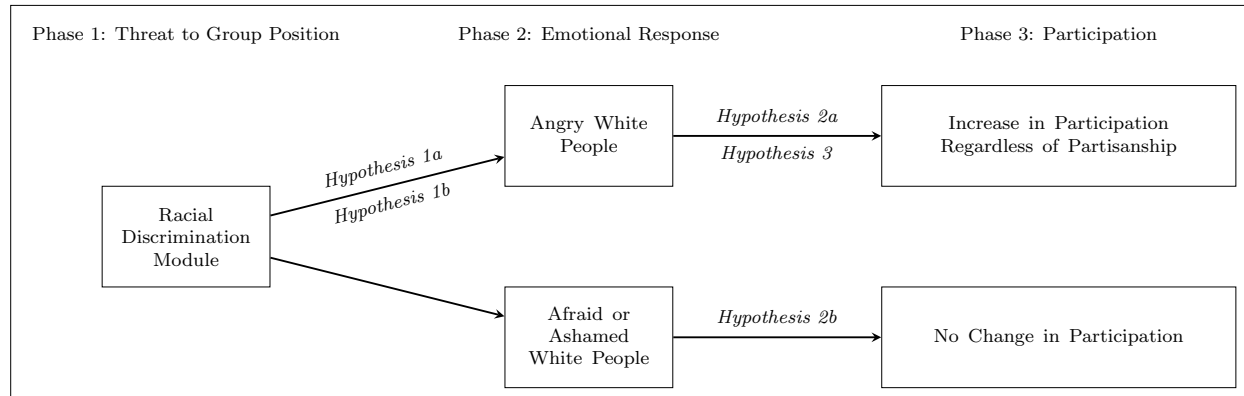
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A Theoretical Expectations

A.1 Theoretical Framework

Figure 1: Theoretical predictions regarding the mediating effects of anger on participation



B Sampling Procedures and Descriptive Statistics

B.1 Experiment Structure

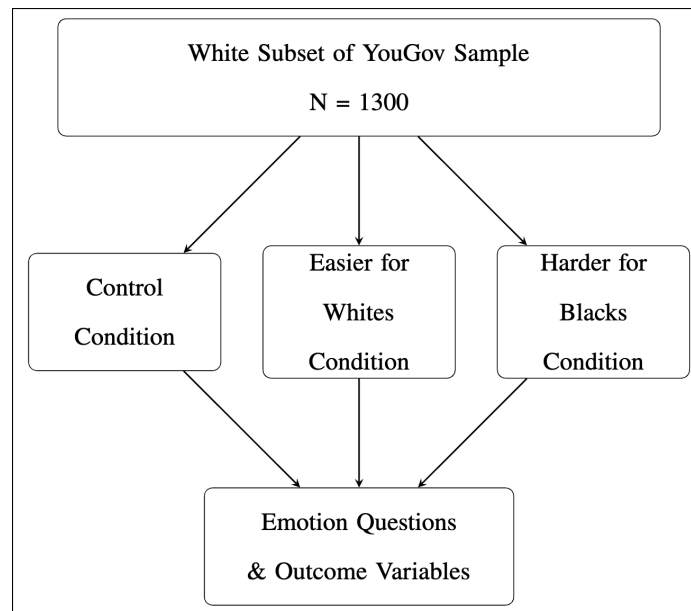


Figure 2: Survey Experimental Design

YouGov interviewed 2031 respondents who were then matched down to a sample of 2000

to produce the final dataset. The respondents were matched to a sampling frame on gender, age, race, and education. The sampling frame is a politically representative "modeled frame" of US adults, based upon the American Community Survey (ACS) public use microdata file, public voter file records, the 2020 Current Population Survey (CPS) Voting and Registration supplements, the 2020 National Election Pool (NEP) exit poll, and the 2020 CES surveys, including demographics and 2020 presidential vote.

The matched cases were weighted to the sampling frame using propensity scores. The matched cases and the frame were combined and a logistic regression was estimated for inclusion in the frame. The propensity score function included age, gender, race/ethnicity, years of education, home ownership status, region and Presidential vote choice. The propensity scores were grouped into deciles of the estimated propensity score in the frame and post-stratified according to these deciles.

The weights were then post-stratified on 2020 Presidential vote choice, and a four-way stratification of gender, age (4-categories), race (4-categories), and education (4-categories), to produce the final weight.

B.2 Sample Descriptive Statistics

Children under 18	Yes	No				
	22%	78%				
Gender	Female	Male				
	51%	49%				
Party ID	Democrat	Republican	Pure independent	Other/Not sure		
	37%	42%	17%	3%		
Education	No HS	HS Diploma	Some college	Two-year	Four-year	Post-grad
	4%	30%	19%	10%	24%	14%
Ideology	Very liberal	Liberal	Moderate	Conservative	Very Conservative	Not Sure
	12%	14%	30%	23%	13%	7%
Age	Min	1st Quarter	Median	Mean	3rd Quarter	Max
	19	41	57	54	67	94

Figure 3: YouGov Sample Statistics

B.3 Sample Size in Each Experimental Condition

	Control	Easier for Whites	Harder for Blacks
1st Dimension			
White	$n = 432$	$n = 448$	$n = 420$
2nd Dimension			
White Republican	$n = 189$	$n = 209$	$n = 182$
White Democrat	$n = 172$	$n = 147$	$n = 155$

Figure 4: Analytical Dimensions and Experimental Conditions

C Design

C.1 Stimuli

Figure 5: Cloud Research Pre-Test Stimuli

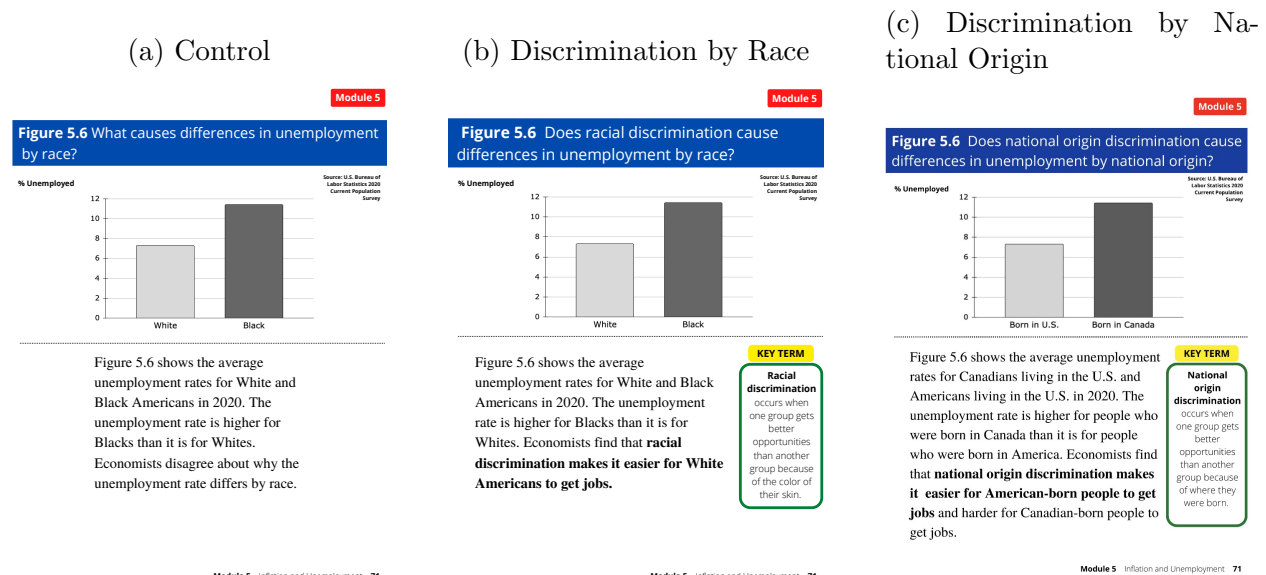
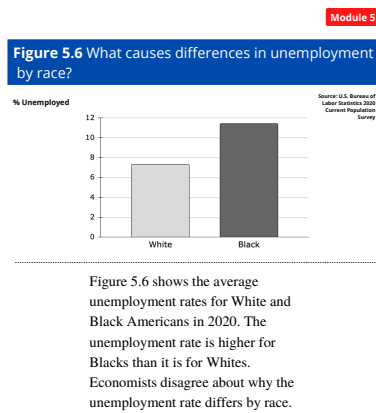


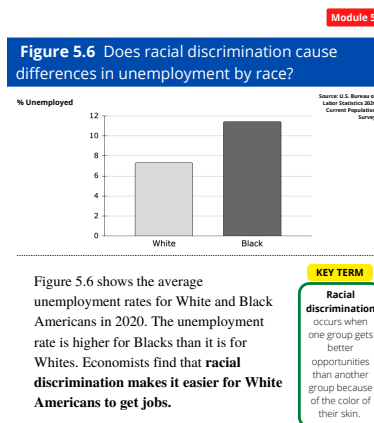
Figure 6: YouGov Stimuli

(a) Control



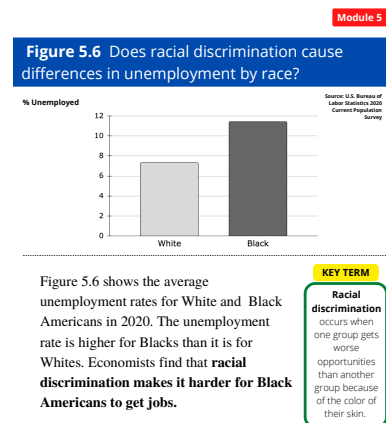
Module 5 Inflation and Unemployment 71

(b) Easier for Whites



Module 5 Inflation and Unemployment 71

(c) Harder for Blacks



Module 5 Inflation and Unemployment 71

Stimuli for each of the three experimental conditions, each an excerpt from a hypothetical middle school social studies textbook. Note that (a) represents the control condition where we do not connect the racial employment gap to racial discrimination. Figure b represents the “easier for whites” condition. And Figure c represents the “harder for blacks” condition.

C.2 Emotion Measure

We measured all four of our composite emotions using a 7-point scale in the shape of a thermometer. Figure 7 shows how this item appeared in the survey for each emotion. Participants were required to move the slider at least to 0 to indicate no emotion.

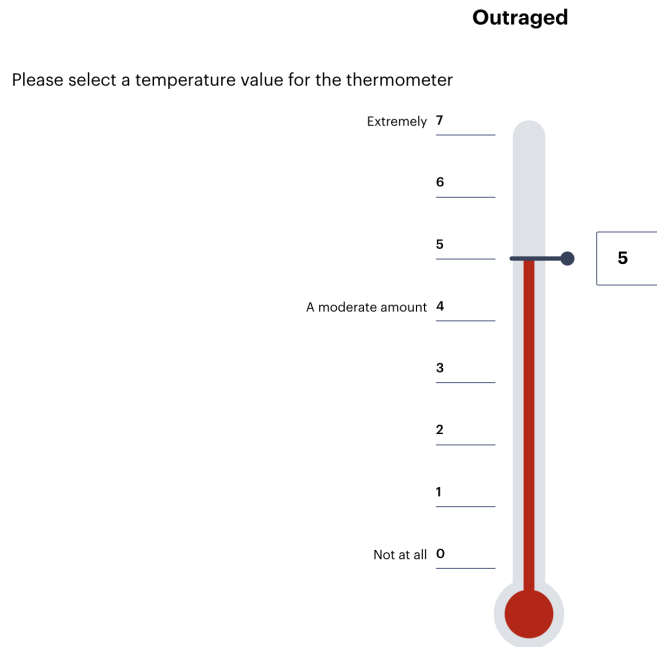


Figure 7: An example of how the slider questions appear measuring each of our 4 composite emotions

C.3 Participation Measure

We measured participation by creating an index of variables gauging intent to participate in 5 activities. Note that all participants were debriefed and informed that their reward would not actually be donated.

Table 1: Distribution of Participation and Intent to Donate Survey Reward

	Not at all	Not very	Somewhat	Very	
How interested are you in participating	23%	30%	35%	12%	
How likely are you to:	Not at all	Not very	Moderately	Very	Extremely
Attend a meeting	46%	29%	15%	7%	4%
Make a comment	52%	26%	13%	6%	3%
Volunteer	52%	27%	13%	5%	3%
Donate	57%	21%	13%	6%	3%
Run for a seat	67%	21%	7%	2%	3%
	No/ Skipped		Yes, to the Equitable Education Fund	Yes, to the Patriot Education Fund	
Would you like to donate your reward	74%		16%	10%	

Results

C.4 Cloud Research Pre-Test: Main Effects on Anger

Table 1 shows the ATE of our textbook treatments on anger among white participants using OLS as the estimator.

Table 1: Average Treatment Effect of Race and National Origin Discrimination on Anger by Partisanship (Output for Figure 4)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	All	Democrat	Republican
National Origin	-0.096*** (0.034)	-0.127*** (0.043)	-0.007 (0.050)
Race	0.112*** (0.036)	0.045 (0.043)	0.196*** (0.051)
Constant	0.364*** (0.024)	0.432*** (0.031)	0.297*** (0.035)
Observations	402	257	208
R ²	0.080	0.063	0.090
Adjusted R ²	0.075	0.055	0.081
Residual Std. Error	0.287 (df = 399)	0.283 (df = 254)	0.297 (df = 205)
F Statistic	17.297*** (df = 2; 399)	8.471*** (df = 2; 254)	10.156*** (df = 2; 205)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

C.5 YouGov: Main Effects on Intent to Participate

We present estimates of the average direct effects (ADE) of the experimental treatments on the participation index and intent to donate outcomes. Tables 2 and 3 show the direct effects of treatment assignment on participation and donating, respectively.

C.6 YouGov: Main effects on other emotions

Tables 4, 5, and 6 present results for the ATE on all four of our composite emotions by analytical dimension (all whites, white Democrat, and white Republican).

Table 2: Direct Effects of Treatments on Participation Index by Partisanship

	<i>Dependent variable: Participation Index</i>		
	(Whites)	(White Democrats)	(White Republicans)
Harder for Blacks	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.026 (0.023)	0.031 (0.027)
Easier for whites	-0.006 (0.014)	-0.025 (0.023)	0.010 (0.028)
Constant	0.165*** (0.010)	0.168*** (0.017)	0.144*** (0.020)
Observations	1,300	445	344
R ²	0.0002	0.004	0.004
Adjusted R ²	-0.001	-0.001	-0.002
Residual Std. Error	0.205 (df = 1297)	0.197 (df = 442)	0.206 (df = 341)
F Statistic	0.106 (df = 2; 1297)	0.815 (df = 2; 442)	0.713 (df = 2; 341)
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01			

Table 3: Direct Effects of Treatment on Intent to Donate by Partisanship

	<i>Dependent variable: Donating</i>		
	(Whites)	(White Democrats)	(White Republicans)
Harder for Blacks	-0.053* (0.030)	-0.110** (0.050)	-0.068 (0.058)
Easier for whites	0.006 (0.030)	-0.025 (0.051)	-0.023 (0.059)
Constant	0.279*** (0.021)	0.297*** (0.037)	0.294*** (0.042)
Observations	1,300	445	344
R ²	0.004	0.012	0.004
Adjusted R ²	0.002	0.008	-0.002
Residual Std. Error	0.440 (df = 1297)	0.432 (df = 442)	0.441 (df = 341)
F Statistic	2.424* (df = 2; 1297)	2.693* (df = 2; 442)	0.718 (df = 2; 341)
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01			

Table 4: Average Treatment Effect on All Composite Emotions for Whites (Output for Figure 5)

	<i>Dependent variable: Composite Emotion</i>			
	Anger (1)	Fear (2)	Shame (3)	Gladness (4)
Harder for Blacks	0.144*** (0.019)	0.037** (0.016)	0.046** (0.019)	-0.020 (0.018)
Easier for whites	0.144*** (0.019)	0.022 (0.016)	0.053*** (0.019)	-0.019 (0.018)
Constant	0.333*** (0.013)	0.217*** (0.012)	0.276*** (0.014)	0.192*** (0.013)
Observations	1,300	1,300	1,300	1,300
R ²	0.057	0.004	0.007	0.001
Adjusted R ²	0.055	0.002	0.005	-0.0003
Residual Std. Error (df = 1297)	0.275	0.239	0.282	0.264
F Statistic (df = 2; 1297)	38.940***	2.622*	4.404**	0.793
<i>Note:</i>		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

Table 5: Average Treatment Effect on All Composite Emotions for White Democrats (Output for Figure 6)

	<i>Dependent variable: Composite Emotion</i>			
	Anger (1)	Fear (2)	Shame (3)	Gladness (4)
Harder for Blacks	0.143*** (0.032)	0.024 (0.027)	0.012 (0.033)	-0.012 (0.031)
Easier for whites	0.102*** (0.032)	0.017 (0.027)	0.041 (0.033)	0.012 (0.031)
Constant	0.349*** (0.023)	0.218*** (0.020)	0.301*** (0.024)	0.176*** (0.023)
Observations	445	445	445	445
R ²	0.046	0.002	0.004	0.001
Adjusted R ²	0.042	-0.003	-0.001	-0.003
Residual Std. Error (df = 442)	0.272	0.231	0.282	0.265
F Statistic (df = 2; 442)	10.653***	0.412	0.795	0.313
<i>Note:</i>		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

Table 6: Average Treatment Effect on All Composite Emotions for White Republicans (Output for Figure 6)

	<i>Dependent variable: Composite Emotion</i>			
	Anger (1)	Fear (2)	Shame (3)	Gladness (4)
Harder for Blacks	0.175*** (0.035)	0.059* (0.032)	0.095*** (0.037)	-0.048 (0.032)
Easier for whites	0.198*** (0.036)	0.043 (0.033)	0.073* (0.038)	-0.035 (0.033)
Constant	0.300*** (0.025)	0.195*** (0.023)	0.251*** (0.027)	0.190*** (0.023)
Observations	344	344	344	344
R ²	0.098	0.010	0.021	0.007
Adjusted R ²	0.093	0.004	0.015	0.001
Residual Std. Error (df = 341)	0.265	0.244	0.279	0.243
F Statistic (df = 2; 341)	18.527***	1.762	3.634**	1.199
<i>Note:</i>		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

C.7 Mediation Results

The following tables include outputs from the “mediate” package for each of our mediation tests reported.

Table 7: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Participation (Output for Figure 10)

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.01101	0.00523	0.02	<2e-16 ***
ADE	-0.01617	-0.04038	0.01	0.19
Total Effect	-0.00516	-0.02842	0.02	0.67
Prop. Mediated	-2.13364	-13.38593	13.34	0.67
—				
Signif. codes:	0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1			
Sample Size Used:	1300	Simulations:	10000	

Recall that “ACME” is the average causal mediate effect while “ADE” is the average direct effect. Here, the DV = Participation. Mediator = Anger

Table 8: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Donating the Reward (Output for Figure 10)

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.01572	0.00261	0.03	0.02 *
ADE	-0.03975	-0.09266	0.01	0.15
Total Effect	-0.02403	-0.07472	0.03	0.37
Prop. Mediated	-0.65429	-6.75861	6.17	0.38
—				
Signif. codes:	0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1			
Sample Size Used:	1300	Simulations:	10000	

DV = Donate Survey Reward. Mediator = Anger

Table 9: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Participation Index for Republicans (Output for Figure 11)

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.020513	0.007847	0.03	0.001 ***
ADE	0.000769	-0.043115	0.05	0.964
Total Effect	0.021282	-0.022306	0.07	0.346
Prop. Mediated	0.963867	-8.155181	8.93	0.347
—				
Signif. codes:	0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1			
Sample Size Used:	344	Simulations:	10000	

DV = Participation. Mediator = Anger

Table 10: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Participation Index for Democrats (Output for Figure 9)

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.01094	0.00219	0.02	0.011 *
ADE	-0.03668	-0.07844	0.00	0.082 .
Total Effect	-0.02573	-0.06688	0.01	0.220
Prop. Mediated	-0.42516	-3.87896	3.65	0.229

—
Signif. codes: 0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1
Sample Size Used: 445 Simulations: 10000
DV = Participation. Mediator = Anger

Table 11: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Donation for Republicans (Output for Figure 11)

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.02870	-0.00502	0.06	0.089
ADE	-0.07547	-0.18446	0.03	0.168
Total Effect	-0.04677	-0.15105	0.06	0.373
Prop. Mediated	-0.61368	-5.89426	5.69	0.435

—
Signif. codes: 0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1
Sample Size Used: 344 Simulations: 10000
DV = Donation. Mediator = Anger

Table 12: Complete Results for Causal Mediation Effects of Anger on Donation for Democrats (Output for Figure 11)

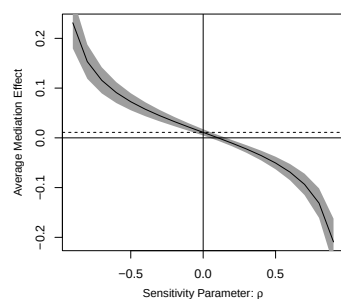
	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value
ACME	0.00494	-0.01468	0.02	0.61
ADE	-0.07403	-0.16833	0.02	0.12
Total Effect	-0.06909	-0.15908	0.02	0.13
Prop. Mediated	-0.07151	-1.10008	0.87	0.64

—
Signif. codes: 0 ‘***’ 0.001 ‘**’ 0.01 ‘*’ 0.05 ‘.’ 0.1 ‘ ’ 1
Sample Size Used: 445 Simulations: 10000
DV = Donation. Mediator = Anger

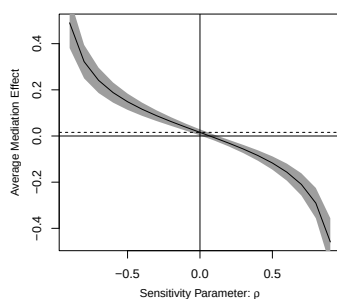
D Sensitivity Analyses of Mediation Effects to Address the Ignorability of Treatment Assignment Assumption

Figure 1: Sensitivity concerning Error Terms

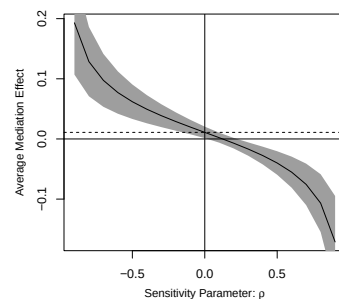
(a) ACME ρ Participation Index for whites



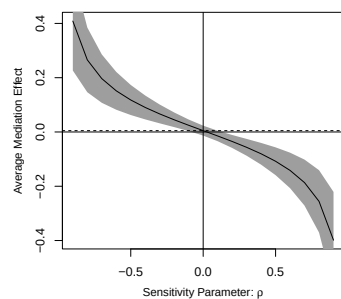
(b) ACME ρ Intent to Donate for whites



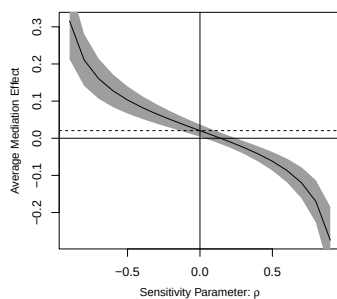
(c) ACME ρ Participation index for white Democrats



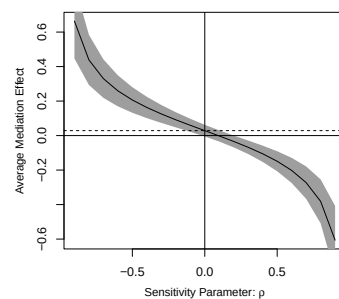
(d) ACME ρ Intent to Donate for white Democrats



(e) ACME ρ Participation Index for white Republicans



(f) ACME ρ Intent to Donate for white Republicans



E Sentiment Analysis and Exemplary Answers

We use the package ‘SentimentAnalysis,’ which employs a dictionary generation approach and utilizes LASSO regularization to identify and select words from texts that are statistically indicative of either positive or negative sentiment. More information about this package is available [here](#).

Additionally, we employ the Harvard IV-4 dictionary to evaluate the sentiment of the responses. More information on the dictionary can be found [here](#). As a second check of our manipulation of anger, we present exemplary responses to the open-ended item. See Roberts, Stewart and Tingley (N.d.) for further details on this method and the ‘stm’ package in R.

Table 1: Sentiment Polarity in Response to Each Condition, By Party ID

Average Sentiment Expressed in the Open Ended Responses
White Respondents Only

Condition	Partisanship	N	word_count	sd	ave_sentiment
Control (Image 3)	Democrat	155	3087	0.3006879	-0.07382
Control (Image 3)	Independent	68	1607	0.2656269	-0.09251
Control (Image 3)	Not Sure	15	236	0.3566609	0.089945
Control (Image 3)	Republican	182	4098	0.2723651	-0.04954
Easier for Whites to get jobs (Image 1)	Democrat	172	3248	0.3533964	-0.09769
Easier for Whites to get jobs (Image 1)	Independent	64	1512	0.3185054	-0.10235
Easier for Whites to get jobs (Image 1)	Not Sure	7	151	0.2219483	-0.10395
Easier for Whites to get jobs (Image 1)	Republican	189	4372	0.3020592	-0.09477
Harder for Blacks to get jobs (Image 2)	Democrat	147	2664	0.3591952	-0.05156
Harder for Blacks to get jobs (Image 2)	Independent	76	1775	0.3421368	-0.09162
Harder for Blacks to get jobs (Image 2)	Not Sure	16	185	0.2224727	-0.17358
Harder for Blacks to get jobs (Image 2)	Republican	209	4682	0.3232456	-0.11476

F Ethical Considerations and Debriefing

F.1 Deception and Consent

We assess public attitudes toward race-conscious education materials. We are attentive to the fact that race is an emotionally potent issue. We minimize the harm to participants by giving them an opportunity to reflect on any negative emotions they might feel in an open-ended response. While the treatments we present are fictitious (that is, they do not represent a real school textbook) they include fully accurate statistics maintained by the U.S. Bureau of Labor. Thus, while respondents might have negative feelings about the information we present, this information is widely publicly available and presented in a format that could easily come across in their daily lives. Moreover, our debrief clarifies the purpose of the study and addresses any potential misunderstandings. Participants are required to click “I confirm” to acknowledge understanding. This clarification was delivered respectfully and in line with best practices for addressing misinformation in survey research (Murphy and Greene 2023; Greenspan and Loftus 2022; Greene et al. 2023). One important design element for us to consider in our experiment is its use of deception. Specifically, we inform respondents that the textbook excerpts they read will be considered for adoption in a local public school curriculum. This deception is necessary for us to evaluate how emotions influences school board participation, but we do not wish to misinform individuals permanently. Consequently, our debrief A) informs respondents that they were deceived and B) stresses that the information they read is accurate, though not being considered for school curricula. Additionally, as we mentioned above, participants are required to confirm that they understand the debrief before finishing the survey. Finally, we have received “exempt approval” by our Institutional Review Board for the pilot and follow-up studies.

F.2 Consent Form for Research Participation

REDACTED

Public Affairs Survey

Principal Investigators: REDACTED

Co-Principal Investigator: REDACTED

Before you begin this survey, please read the following:

You are invited to participate in a research study with the REDACTED FOR ANONYMOUS VERSION. The survey should take approximately 10 minutes to complete. If you agree to be part of this research, you will be asked to answer questions about your feelings about politics. REDACTED FOR ANONYMOUS VERSION, researchers at REDACTED, are conducting this research.

The risks involved in these studies are minimal. Findings will be reported in scholarly journals, at academic seminars, and at research association meetings. The data will be stored in a secured location and retained indefinitely, but your responses will remain anonymous. None of your responses can be linked to you. Your participation is voluntary. You are free not to answer any questions or to withdraw from the study at any time.

Please note that the purposes/procedures of this research will not be revealed to you until after completing this survey.

Should you have any questions or concerns about this study, please contact REDACTED FOR ANONYMOUS VERSION (research.contact.q@gmail.com).

By clicking below, you confirm that you understand the following:

- Your participation in the study is voluntary.
- You are at least 18 years of age.
- You are aware that you may choose to terminate your participation at any time for any reason.

[I am at least 18 years of age and I consent, begin the study]

F.3 Debriefing

Thank you for your participation in our research study.

We want to discuss with you in more detail the study you just participated in and explain exactly what the purpose of this study is. We are interested in understanding more about racial attitudes and local political participation.

In this study, you read a short prompt about a publishing company's proposed textbook. The information provided to you was **not** based on any actual textbook being considered by a publisher. While the data presented in the excerpt was accurate, it was designed by the researchers solely for the purposes of this project.

If you have any further questions about this study, please do not hesitate to contact the research team at: `research.contact.q@gmail.com`

Acknowledgement:

- I understand that the excerpt used in this survey was fake and not based on any actual textbook being proposed by a publisher.

We really appreciate your participation in this study! Please provide any additional comments, thoughts, or questions below. Your feedback will help to develop this research even more.

[NEXT: End survey and record my responses]
